Top-20 war-history competitors: what works (thumbnails + format) - owner study 2026-11-07

Data: vidIQ channel pulls (top ~10 popular + ~10 recent long videos per channel), 457 videos, 20 thumbnail sheets (`thumbs/<handle>_sheet.jpg`, one overview `thumbs/ALL_top3_per_channel.jpg`), 2 transcripts per channel where narrated (`<handle>.md` / `.json`). Channel list + ids: `channels.json`. Our baseline: `research/COMPETITOR_ANALYSIS.md` (Tactical Genius), `research/NICHE_ANALYSIS.md`.

Caveats (read first): (1) "outlier" = views / median of the last ~10-50 uploads, so 2018-2021 winners are inflated (years of views vs days): use for ranking and patterns, not as a forecast. (2) Words per minute and "% of winners with X" are agent estimates from ~12 thumbnails per channel (the agents' labels are not uniform); treat percentages as direction, not statistics. (3) 5 of the 20 are not comparable: Wartime (feature films), Johnny's War Stories (film clips), War Archives (dormant newsreels), Animarchy (1-3 h commentary), Timeline (non-war evergreens); History Hit is a presenter/documentary channel. Most comparable to us: HistoryMarche, Eastory, Operations Room, Kings and Generals, Armchair Historian, Epic History.

The 21 channels at a glance (21 = Commanders and Tactics, added by the owner 2026-11-07, see its own section below)

#	Channel	Subs	Recent median	Best long video	Thumbnail trait	Format trait
1	Kings and Generals	4.2M	327k	Rome conquers Greece 20.3M	illustration over a faded map + 3-5 word caps headline	background-first chronology, sponsor at 0:10, 30-170 min
2	Epic History TV	3.2M	927k	Alexander (All Parts) 29.3M	one fixed cream/red template, one big word, painted face	opens on the key moment/quote; "(All Parts)" compilations
3	Armchair Historian	2.5M	430k	D-Day from the German perspective 8.4M	cartoon face, 0-3 words	"other side's view" angle series; sponsor before content
4	Mark Felton	2.4M	328k	Nazi Princesses 12.1M	real archive photo, NO text	7-15 min, ends on a twist fact
5	Military History Visualized	0.8M	79k	Panzerfaust 4.1M	fixed template, red ribbon, ~5 caps words	one verdict question in the first sentence
6	Operations Room	1.5M	538k	Desert Storm air war 14.0M	one iconic subject + 1-8 words, channel name on every thumb	clock-stamped 60-90 s vignettes, cold open with a deadline
7	HistoryMarche	1.3M	343k	Hattin 5.4M	OWN animated-map frame + arrow + 2-4 caps words (closest to us)	counter-intuitive claim titles; weekly slot
8	Timeline	5.9M	49k	(non-war evergreens)	no text	"13 hours" time-boxing, minute-by-minute
9	War Stories	1.4M	50k	Hiroshima footage 13.9M	text-free colourised faces + one saturated accent	licensed TV episodes, cliffhanger + recap every ~11 min
10	Wartime	1.2M	64k	(feature films)	text-free film stills	n/a
11	Dark Docs	1.2M	101k	Concorde 9.5M / Vietnam man 9.1M	8 of 8 winners ZERO text: one big face or one red-circled/arrowed detail	cold open in action, hero named <15 s, one repeated quote
12	Animarchy	225k	229k	airshow collision 2.3M	2-4 words on a series banner	1-3 h commentary, not transferable
13	HistoryAtWar	225k	96k	Kursk footage 3.0M	colourised footage, no text	Normandy cold open on one named witness, stakes by 2 min
14	History Explorer	553k	117k	D-Day through German eyes 2.2M	bottom bar, white caps + ONE red word	promise + open loop in the first 50 s
15	War Archives	272k	93k	FDR declares war 11.8M	fixed blue-bar template	dormant newsreels
16	Johnny's War Stories	274k	6k	The Pianist clip 10.8M	close-up film stills, no text	film clips
17	Eastory	482k	180k	Eastern Front 1944/45 10.3M	7 of 8 winners = map + ONE big place name	flat dated opening, sector by sector, plan -> result -> decision loop
18	Liveth for Evermore	313k	34k	Pirates mistook a warship 13.6M	one clean photo + red label bar 2-6 words	slow context opening, 5-6 min
19	History Hit	2.0M	189k	(history, not war-specific) 11.3M	host face + a quote as the text	explicit promise in 60 s, date cold open then rewind
20	World History	557k	179k	Irma Grese 5.0M	faces, no text	dated shock scene at 0:00, then ~8 min background
21	**Commanders and Tactics**	38k	250k	Napoleon's Top 3 815k	ALL 9: one big colourised face + saturated red-arrow map + 2-5 caps words, winners add a curiosity line	'Top 3 Tactical Masterpieces' mini-documentary, general named <30 s, no recap, abrupt ending; 1 video / ~56 days

What works: THUMBNAILS (patterns across the 20)

1. **One focal subject, readable at feed size.** Every winner reads in 168x94: ONE face, ONE iconic object or ONE map with one named place. Busy maps with 6-7 words and small icons are the common weak thumbnail (Operations Room, HistoryMarche weak videos, Epic's 12-word Tsarist Russia).
2. **Text: few words or none.** Winners average ~2.6 words (median 3); 38 % of winner thumbnails have no text at all (Mark Felton, Dark Docs 8/8, War Stories, Timeline, Wartime). When there is text it is 1-5 words in heavy caps, with ONE accent colour (red word, red bar, red ribbon).
3. **A face wins more often than a map, but maps win for battle topics.** About two thirds of winners carry a face (real photo, colourised portrait, painted or cartoon). Maps are ~1 in 5 of winners overall, but 75 % of HistoryMarche's best 8 and 7 of 8 of Eastory's: a map thumbnail works only when it shows ONE named place + ONE arrow/front line.
4. **One brand template per channel** (Epic cream/red, MHV red ribbon, History Explorer bottom bar, War Archives blue bar, Operations Room channel name bottom-left): recognisable in the sidebar. Variety is not rewarded.
5. **Emotion / mystery beats information:** wide-eyed or grim close-ups, a red circle on one odd detail (Dark Docs), a quote as text ("THE SOUND IS DEAFENING!").

6. **Colour:** muted base (grey-blue, olive, sepia, b&w) with ONE hot accent (red) dominates; cream/red/black is the Epic/MHV look.
7. **What the title adds:** the thumbnail names the subject, the title carries the angle, the number or the curiosity gap; the best pairs never repeat the same words.

What works: TITLES

- Plain subject + year + "- Animated" (Operations Room, K&G "DOCUMENTARY") wins on famous topics; famous Western-audience topics beat niche ones by 5-10x (Desert Storm, Midway, D-Day, Caesar, Rome, Mongols).
- **Angle titles** repeat: "<Battle> from the <other side's> view" (Armchair 8.4M, History Explorer 2.2M), "How One <thing> Destroyed <empire>" (HistoryMarche 6.6x), "When <X> mistook a <Y> for a <Z>" (Liveth 13.6M), "The Most Terrifying Man..." (Dark Docs), superlative question ("The Greatest ...?", Epic).
- Median winning title ~54 characters, almost never caps, rarely a number; named person or place + one stake word.
- "Part N" / "All Parts" / series numbers lose 15-50 % (Operations Room, Eastory 0.7x).

What works: FORMAT

- **Hook:** the winners with a strong hook open on ONE concrete moment (Epic: the Opis speech 16M from a 7:39 video; Dark Docs: cold open in action, hero named <15 s; History at War: one named witness + one quote + what was about to be lost; Operations Room: "in 35 hours a war will have started"; World History: dated scene with a hard number at 0:00). The weak openers are background-first (K&G sponsor at 0:10 then chronology; Ops Room 100 s background; Eastory flat dated opening; Liveth 45 s context): they win only on mega-topics.
- **Sponsor/channel-promo before the content (Armchair 0-1:36, K&G 0:10, History Explorer 3-4 min Patreon) = the competitor mistake. Keep asks late.**
- **Structure:** 3-7 self-contained acts; clock-stamped vignettes with one number each (Ops Room, Timeline); plan -> result -> decision-beat loop (Eastory); ending on a twist fact (Felton) or a cliffhanger + recap (War Stories, every ~11 min).
- **Length:** hits exist at every length. 7-20 min for single stories (Felton 7-15, Epic Opis 7:39, Armchair 20, Operations Room ~35-60); 1-3 h compilations draw clicks for K&G/Epic but are not our format. Our ~16 min Top-3 sits inside the proven band.
- **Series fatigue:** a second/third part of the same subject, or many near-identical videos in a row, falls 15-50 % (Ops Room, MHV 2026 StuG series, Eastory RCW parts).
- **Topic beats packaging:** the same channel's best and worst differ 5-60x mostly by topic fame (Caesar x3 in K&G's top 6; Desert Storm/Midway at Ops Room; obscure battles 0.3-0.5x of median). Lead our Top-3 with the most famous move.
- **Decline of the old winners:** 14 of the 20 channels' 2026 uploads sit at 0.1-0.5x of their old winners; the Armchair Historian owner announced retirement end of 2026. Evergreen back-catalogue carries many of these channels, new videos do not.

Channel 21: Commanders and Tactics (our nearest rival: the same "<General>'s Top 3 ..." format) - details in `commandersandtactics.md`

- 37.9k subs, only 9 long videos, one upload every ~56 days, median 250k views. Best: Napoleon 815k (3.3x, the SHORTEST at 11:09); the three Eastern Front WW2 videos (Zhukov, Model, Manstein) are all hits (1.9-2.4x); ancient generals are mid (Caesar 229k, Alexander 143k); Lee only 43k (low-contrast thumbnail, no "Top 3", 20:38).
- **Thumbnail recipe on all 9:** ONE large colourised face + a saturated red-arrow map + 2-5 caps words; winners add a curiosity line ("PROLONGED WW2 BY A YEAR?"). Their title is identical for hits and flops: the GENERAL'S NAME is the lever, not the wording.
- **"(No AI)" label:** in the titles of Zhukov, Model, Manstein (their hits), never on a thumbnail; confounded with topic, so no proof it adds views. We use an AI voice: do NOT copy it unless it becomes true.
- **Format:** thesis hook, general named within 30 s, three dated battles, NO recap, abrupt ending; Manstein has a 90 s sponsor read inside move 1 (watch-time risk). Newest video: 482k in 19 days, stable rate fell from 36k/day (day 11) to ~10.8k/day.
- **They cover none of our 10 generals.** Eastern Front is their audience: Patton and Rokossovsky look like the best next pair for us; Civil War is their weak spot (Lee 43k).
- **What they do better:** the thumbnail recipe, name demand, Eastern Front topics. **What we do better:** stakes + number hook (not a CV-style thesis), map + sound design, recap and casualty/result cards, move-end cards.

- **Apply:** test their recipe on ours (colourised portrait + our red front-line map + 2-5 caps words + one curiosity line); keep our length at ~16 min (their shortest hit was the best); put the most famous general first.

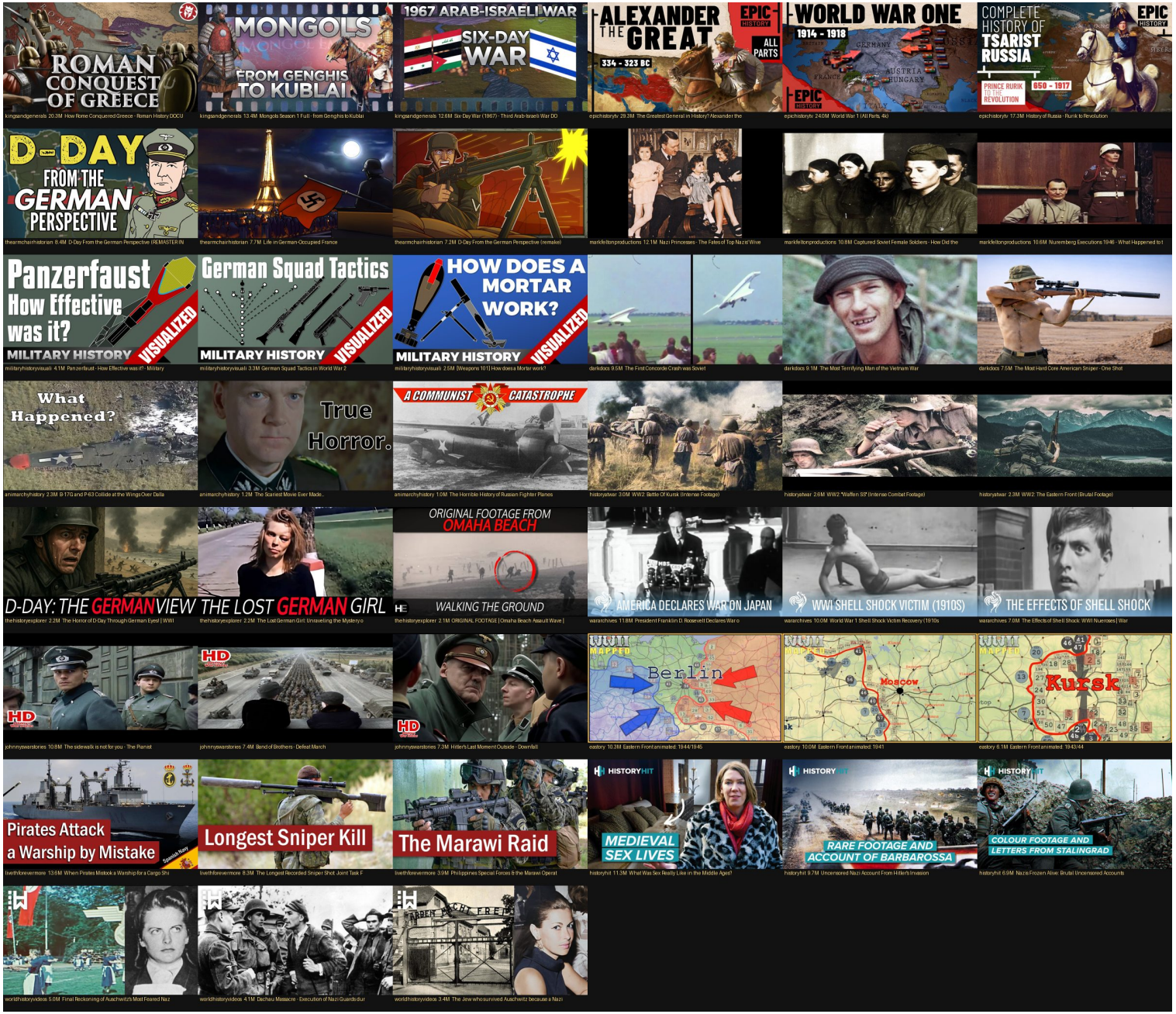
What this means for us (to apply, in priority order)

1. **Thumbnail test set** (fits Test & Compare): (A) general's portrait + 1-3 caps words + ONE red accent; (B) our own Style W map frame with ONE named place + ONE arrow + 1-3 words (HistoryMarche/Eastory pattern, "HATTIN, 1187" style) - check it reads at 168x94; (C) a real archive face with NO text (Felton/Dark Docs) or a circled mystery detail. Use ONE brand template (colour + logo corner) on every video of the channel.
2. **Titles:** keep A (locked format), and make B/C angle titles: "How <X> ..." counter-intuitive claim, "when <army> walked into its own trap", "<Battle> from the <losing side's> view", "The Man Who ...". Every claim true and sourced.
3. **Hook:** our stakes-first hook is the differentiator; add the best competitor devices: a hard odds number in the first sentence (War Stories), name the hero by ~0:15-0:50 (Dark Docs, we have 0:50), one repeated signature line as the spine (Dark Docs), and a clock/deadline cold open for move 1 (Ops Room) - all inside the existing opening rule (no background before move 1).
4. **Move structure:** copy the Ops Room clock-stamped vignettes with one number each, close every move on a twist/result line (Felton) with a one-sentence recap into the next move (War Stories); this matches our casualty/result card rule and DATA RULES (minutes watched).
5. **Never:** sponsor/asks before the content, "Part N" or "All Parts", background-first openings, 8+ word thumbnails, shock/gore or Nazi-leader gimmicks (monetisation and brand risk), SS insignia in thumbnails.
6. **Topic order:** put the most famous battle/move first; famous Western-audience topics beat niche ones by 5-10x. Do not repeat a winning subject family until the audience is still there (Liveth lost ~90 % after its pivot).
7. **Measure:** log which test thumbnail/title wins and the day 1-3 impressions per traffic source (CHANNEL_LOG), separate from retention.

Open questions for the owner

- Which thumbnails of ours do you want redone first (Grant main = D "BEHIND ENEMY LINES"; check the new set against it)?
- Do you want the same 20-channel pull repeated monthly (about 400 vidIQ credits) to track which formats are rising?

Overview: the top 3 thumbnails of each channel (views in M under each)



Channel 21: Commanders and Tactics (our nearest rival), 9 long videos



Napoleon: 815,060 views, 3.35x median



Zhukov: 596,376 views, 2.45x median



Model: 497,042 views, 2.04x median



Manstein: 482,151 views, 1.98x median



Rommel: 249,750 views, 1.03x median



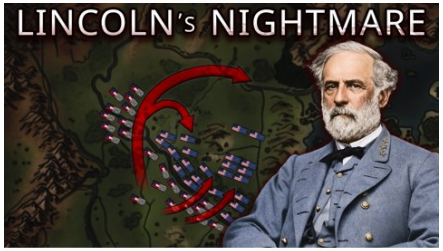
Suvorov: 231,904 views, 0.95x median



Caesar: 229,286 views, 0.94x median



Alexander: 143,474 views, 0.59x median



Lee: 42,663 views, 0.18x median